

ANTI-HINDI AGITATION

Tongue TIED

An anti-Hindi agitation made a Periyar of E.V.Ramasamy and had Annadurai famously say that if Hindi should be the official language because it was spoken by a majority, the common crow and not the peacock would have to be the national bird

■ By A.R. Venkatachalapathy

Let there be a solution not necessarily by us. We are not the last scions of India. Perhaps we are confused. We have more political rancour. In future times a proper solution may be arrived at.... It is my request, it is my pleading and I would say that on a solution of this issue depends the entire political future.... —C.N. Annadurai, Rajya Sabha, May 1963

In a now perhaps justly forgotten book, ominously called *India: The Most Dangerous Decade*, published in 1960, US analyst Selig Harrison—like a prophet of doom—had predicted, “the risk of India being split up into a number of totalitarian small nationalities”. The one prominent seed-bed of discontent Harrison identified was the Tamil south. Even though the rising Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) formally foreswore secession from

the Indian union in the wake of the Chinese aggression, this was one prediction of Harrison which was not too far off the mark.

The seeds of language conflict were present even in the founding moment of India as its Constitution was being drafted by a far-from democratically-elected Constituent Assembly. With a boycott by Muslim League representatives, the assembly was little more than a Congress legislature party. Language was a chink in the nationalist armour throughout the long anti-colonial struggle. Even at the turn of the twentieth century, attempts were made by well-meaning nationalists—the great Tamil poet Subramania Bharati, for instance—to popularise the teaching of Hindi. But the Hindi zealots were not particularly helpful with their end-
WAGING WAR: An anti-Hindi protest in Coimbatore

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